



VOWELS AND CONSONANTS

The two basic building blocks of every English word

1 What is it?

Vowels and Consonants (VOW-elz / KON-suh-nunts)

Vowels (a, e, i, o, u — and sometimes y) are speech sounds made with an open airflow. Consonants are every other letter, made by partly or fully blocking the airflow in the mouth.

5 vowels + 21 consonants = 26 letters

2 See it in action

Vowels

"**a, e, i, o, u** — and sometimes **y** (as in 'myth' or 'gym')"

In a word

"**Cat**: c and t are consonants, a is the vowel."

Consonants

"**b, c, d, f, g...** — every letter that isn't a vowel"

Y as a vowel

"**Gym, myth, rhythm** — here, y makes a vowel sound."



You got this!

Try counting the syllables in a long word by counting its vowel sounds — it's a genuinely reliable trick.

3 More to know

Silent letters

"**Knight, thumb, listen** — English has lots of silent consonants."

Double vowels

"**Book, rain, pie** — two vowels can combine to make one sound."

FUN FACT

"Rhythm" and "myth" are two of very few common English words that contain no standard vowel (a, e, i, o, u) at all — both rely entirely on "y" to carry their vowel sound.

4 Why it's used

Vowels and Consonants help: form the foundation of every single word and syllable in the English language — understanding the difference helps with spelling rules, syllable counting, and pronunciation.

A syllable almost always needs at least one vowel sound — that's actually how you count syllables in a word (cat = 1, ta-ble = 2, won-der-ful = 3).



Think about...

Watch for 'y' doing double duty — a consonant at the start of a word, a vowel almost everywhere else.

5 Where you'll spot it

Vowels

a, e, i, o, u — sometimes joined by y — carry the 'open' sound at the centre of a syllable.

Consonants

Every other letter, formed by blocking or shaping airflow with the lips, teeth or tongue.

⚠ Watch out!

"Y" is the trickiest letter in English — it acts as a consonant at the start of a word ("yellow", "yes") but as a vowel sound in the middle or end of many others ("myth", "happy").

6 Quick recap

5 main vowels + y

21 consonants

Every syllable needs a vowel sound



Look here!

If you're ever unsure whether a word is one or two syllables, say it slowly out loud and count the vowel sounds you hear.